



Wired Headphones

Audio bliss, the traditional way

Today's market is packed with options when it comes to wired headphones, from affordable studio monitors that start in the low thousands to premium models that can cost over ₹5,00,000. The leap in audio quality as you climb the price ladder is huge, though eventually, you hit a point where the return on investment starts to flatten out. Still, with so many different niches to explore, finding the right fit can be a bit of a journey. The gap in performance and the value proposition between these types of headphones can be tricky to define, but we have the answer for you.

Winner: Sony MDR-M1

Out of the box, the sound profile of the Sony MDR-M1 is impressively neutral, with mids and lows close to what you'd expect from a reference headphone. The real magic happens in the highs, which are subtly boosted, giving vocals a bit of extra sparkle without overwhelming the rest of the track. Instrument separation and layering are excellent. This is especially useful in a studio setting where you need pinpoint accuracy in mixing. Vocals, thanks to that slight high-end boost, come through clearly, adding presence to even the most complex arrangements. Metal and high-frequency sounds are represented beautifully, without any harsh sibilance, even at high volumes. Speaking of which, the MDR-M1s maintain their clarity up to around 102dB, with zero distortion, no matter how loud you go. The closed-back design offers an intimate soundstage, but compared to other studio monitors, the MDR-M1s feel surprisingly wide. That is what brings these headphones to the top spot in the Wired Headphones Category of the Digit Zero1 Awards 2024.



Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus
Price: ₹39,900



Sony MDR-M1
Price: ₹14,990

Runner-Up: Sennheiser HD 620S

At 670 grams, the HD 620S is on the heavier side but surprisingly comfortable. When it comes to sound, the HD 620S delivers a balanced experience with a slight boost in the highs. The lows and mids are pretty close to flat, giving a clear and detailed sound. This makes them great for studio environments or for those who love genres like classical and soul. The noise isolation is good, thanks to the snug fit of the earcups. However, for gaming, the bass is a bit lacking. Priced at ₹27,990, the Sennheiser HD 620S is a solid choice if you're looking for professional-grade headphones, however, they lost out to Sony MDR-M1s when it came to raw performance, slotting right behind them in the runner-up spot.



Sennheiser HD 620S
Price: ₹32,990

Best Buy: Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus

The Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus are a strong contender in the pro audio space, offering both performance and comfort. They are incredibly light yet sturdy. While the build quality is solid, the bulky carrying case is something to note. While protective, it's not the most portable, which could be a concern for those looking for something more travel-friendly. When it comes to performance, the HD 490 Pro Plus delivers. The neutral sound profile with the fabric earpads is excellent for studio work, offering clear, balanced audio. The velour earpads add warmth, giving the sound a fuller, more bass-heavy feel. The open-back design creates an expansive soundstage, perfect for critical listening or gaming. Audio localisation is fantastic, making these headphones a solid choice for competitive gaming. Whether you're mixing audio or gaming, these headphones handle both with ease. This well rounded nature, with a banging value for money proposition, got these headphones the top spot in the Digit Best Buy Awards 2024.

—Sativik Pandey | sativik@digit.in